Excitation-Aware Friction Capability Bounds for Uncertainty-Aware Speed Planning of Autonomous Ground Vehicles

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***Abstract*— Speed planners must respect the tire–road friction limit, yet the friction coefficient is rarely known and can only be identified when the tires operate near saturation. We show that, for a saturating tire model, the Fisher information about friction carried by a measurement scales with the sixth power of tire utilisation at low utilisation, so ordinary driving leaves friction essentially unidentified and a friction estimate can stay stale after the road changes. We propose an excitation-aware lower confidence bound on friction, computed by an estimator whose forgetting relaxes both the estimate and its information toward a conservative prior, and whose trust additionally decays with distance travelled since the tires were last informatively excited. The bound feeds a forward–backward speed planner on the friction circle with a conditional feasibility property. In a 20-run Monte Carlo study with ±10% tire-stiffness mismatch, the planner reduces tire-saturation time after a hidden friction drop from 31.5 ± 3.2 s for certainty-equivalent planning to 0.2 ± 0.1 s, with no lane departures versus departures in every run, while recovering 71% of the traversal-time gap between a fixed conservative and a fixed nominal planner on high friction. We also show where the method fails: overestimating the cornering stiffness by 20% leads to persistent saturation on low friction.**

Index Terms*— *Motion and path planning, autonomous vehicle navigation, robot safety, calibration and identification.

1 Introduction

The acceleration available to a road vehicle is bounded by the tire–road friction coefficient μ. Every speed planner that commands a vehicle through a curve therefore relies, explicitly or implicitly, on a value of μ. Dry asphalt supports roughly $\mu \approx 1$, while wet or snowy surfaces can fall below 0.3; a planner tuned for one surface is either unsafe or inefficient on the other.

Online friction estimation is mature [1–3], but a basic difficulty remains: in the linear region of the tire curve the force produced for a given slip does not depend on μ. Friction is observable only when the tires approach saturation. Ordinary driving, which by design keeps utilisation low, gives an estimator almost no information about the friction limit. A planner that uses the estimate as if it were exact (*certainty equivalence*) inherits whatever value the estimator last converged to—exactly the failure mode when a dry road turns wet on a straight.

Planning and control methods at the handling limits either assume μ known [4,5], use a spatial friction map [6], or adapt constraints to a friction estimate [7, 8]. What is missing is a principled way to make the *confidence* in μ—not only its value—depend on how much, and how recently and how far away, the tires were excited.

This letter makes three contributions:

1. An analysis showing that the Fisher information about μ in a single measurement scales as ρ^6 at low tire utilisation ρ, quantifying why mild driving is uninformative.
2. An excitation-aware lower confidence bound $\underline{\mu}$ on friction, using stabilised forgetting toward a conservative prior and a spatial staleness term anchored at the last informative excitation.
3. A friction-circle speed planner using $\underline{\mu}$ with a conditional feasibility result, and a Monte Carlo study against fixed, conservative and certainty-equivalent baselines and two ablations, including a sensitivity analysis that exposes the method's main failure mode. All code is released [TODO: repository URL].

2 Related Work

Friction estimation. Slip-based methods estimate μ from the force–slip relationship [1]; model-based methods identify friction from vehicle motion [2]; a survey compares experiment- and model-based approaches [3]. Estimates converge only under sufficient excitation, linking friction estimation to persistent excitation in identification [10] and adaptive control [11, 12]. Stabilised forgetting, which relaxes toward a prior instead of letting covariance grow, is established in recursive estimation [13].

Friction-aware planning and control. Envelope controllers keep the vehicle within stable handling limits [4]; emergency planners exploit the full friction circle [5]; time-optimal racing trajectories have been planned for locally varying, known friction [6]. Svensson *et al.* represent traction variations over the horizon by time-varying tire-force constraints derived from a predictive friction estimate [7]. A

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recent two-layer framework combines time-optimal planning with indirect adaptive robust control and monitors the estimate to keep plans feasible [8]. Minimum-time speed profiles are commonly computed by forward–backward passes [9]. These works use the friction estimate or a friction map; none ties the planning margin to the information actually accumulated from tire excitation.

Confidence-aware decisions. Self-normalised confidence sets for regression [14] motivate using estimation covariance directly in decisions. We use a simpler scalar, approximate bound tailored to a saturating tire model and make its excitation dependence explicit.

[TODO: Complete the systematic search (IEEE Xplore, Scopus, 2020–2026) and check that no prior work proposes an excitation-dependent friction confidence bound for planning; adjust the novelty claim if one exists.]

3 Problem Formulation

3.1 Vehicle and friction constraint

The vehicle follows a reference path with arc length s and curvature $\kappa(s)$. A speed profile $v(s)$ produces lateral acceleration $a_y = v^2\kappa$ and longitudinal acceleration $a_x = v\,\mathrm{d}v/\mathrm{d}s$. With a point-mass friction-circle approximation, feasibility requires

$$\sqrt{a_x^2 + a_y^2} \le \eta\,\mu\,g, \tag{1}$$

with g gravitational acceleration and $\eta \in (0,1]$ a safety factor absorbing load transfer and model error.

3.2 Tire model and measurements

For the front axle we use the normalised saturating model

$$y = \frac{F_{yf}}{F_{zf}} = h(\alpha;\mu) = \mu \tanh\left(\frac{c\,\alpha}{\mu}\right), \tag{2}$$

where α is the front slip angle and $c = C_f/F_{zf}$ the normalised cornering stiffness. For small α, $h \approx c\alpha$ independently of μ; for large $|\alpha|$, $|h| \to \mu$. Tire utilisation is $\rho = |h|/\mu = \tanh|u|$, $u = c\alpha/\mu$.

The front-axle lateral force is reconstructed from lateral acceleration a_y and yaw acceleration $\dot r$,

$$F_{yf} = \frac{m\,l_r\,a_y + I_z\,\dot r}{L\cos\delta}, \tag{3}$$

with mass m, yaw inertia I_z, axle distances l_f, l_r, wheelbase L and steering angle δ; the static load $F_{zf} = mgl_r/L$ is used. The slip angle is computed from estimated lateral velocity and yaw rate. Measurements are $y_k = h(\alpha_k;\mu) + n_k$ with noise variance R.

Assumption 1. *(i) Model* (2) *holds with known c; (ii) n_k is i.i.d. Gaussian; (iii) μ is constant over the estimator memory; (iv) $\mu \in [\mu_{\min}, \mu_{\max}]$ with known bounds.*

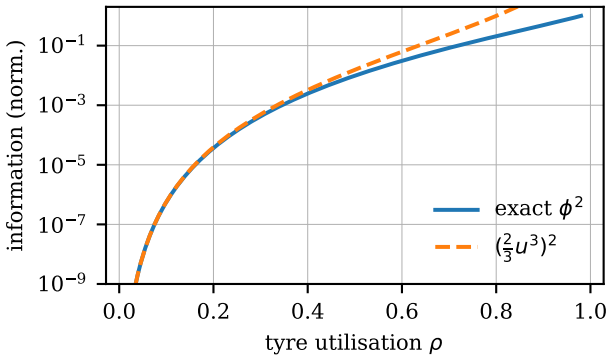


Figure 1: Fisher information about μ per measurement versus tire utilisation, normalised to $\rho = 0.98$. The series (5) matches the exact value below $\rho \approx 0.5$.

3.3 Problem

Given measurements up to time k, compute $\underline{\mu}_k$ such that $\mu \ge \underline{\mu}_k$ with high probability, and plan $v(s)$ satisfying (1) with μ replaced by a planning value derived from $\underline{\mu}_k$, so that the plan is feasible whenever the bound holds while being as fast as the available information allows.

4 Excitation-Aware Friction Bound

4.1 Information carried by one measurement

Differentiating (2) with respect to μ gives the sensitivity

$$\phi(\alpha;\mu) = \frac{\partial h}{\partial \mu} = \tanh u - u\,\mathrm{sech}^2 u, \qquad u = \frac{c\alpha}{\mu}. \tag{4}$$

With $\tanh u = u - u^3/3 + O(u^5)$ and $u\,\mathrm{sech}^2 u = u - u^3 + O(u^5)$,

$$\phi = \tfrac{2}{3}u^3 + O(u^5). \tag{5}$$

The Fisher information of one measurement is ϕ^2/R, which scales as u^6; since $\rho \approx |u|$ at low utilisation, information scales as ρ^6. Evaluating (4) exactly, a measurement at $\rho = 0.3$ carries 8.7×10^{-4} of the information of one at $\rho = 0.9$, and one at $\rho = 0.5$ carries 2.0×10^{-2} (Fig. 1).

4.2 Estimator with stabilised forgetting

Each update first blends the information $J = P^{-1}$ and its mean with the prior (μ_0, J_0), then applies a scalar Gauss–Newton step:

$$J_k^- = \lambda J_{k-1} + (1-\lambda)J_0, \tag{6}$$

$$\mu_k^- = \big(\lambda J_{k-1}\hat\mu_{k-1} + (1-\lambda)J_0\mu_0\big)/J_k^-, \tag{7}$$

$$J_k = J_k^- + \phi_k^2/R, \quad \phi_k = \phi(\alpha_k;\mu_k^-), \tag{8}$$

$$\hat\mu_k = \Pi\left[\mu_k^- + \frac{\phi_k}{J_k R}\big(y_k - h(\alpha_k;\mu_k^-)\big)\right], \tag{9}$$

with forgetting factor $\lambda \in (0,1)$ and Π a projection onto admissible values. Without excitation ($\phi_k \approx 0$), both $J_k \to J_0$ and $\hat{\mu}_k \to \mu_0$ geometrically: the estimator returns to its prior instead of winding up its covariance or keeping a stale mean. With sustained excitation, J_k approaches $J_0 + \bar{\phi}^2/(R(1-\lambda))$.

Remark 1. *After strong excitation the information can exceed J_0 by orders of magnitude, and returning to J_0 takes about $\ln(J_{\text{peak}}/J_0)/(1-\lambda)$ samples. With $\lambda = 0.995$ at 100 Hz and $J_{\text{peak}}/J_0 \approx 2.7 \times 10^3$ this is about 16 s—roughly 400 m at highway speed. Time-based forgetting alone therefore cannot distinguish standing still from driving onto a new surface; this motivates the spatial term below.*

4.3 Lower confidence bound

The bound is

$$\underline{\mu}_k = \max\{\mu_{\min},\ \hat{\mu}_k - z_\delta J_k^{-1/2}\}, \tag{10}$$

with z_δ the one-sided Gaussian quantile for confidence $1-\delta$. The prior satisfies $\mu_0 - z_\delta J_0^{-1/2} = \mu_{\min}$, so with no information the bound equals the conservative value.

Remark 2. *Under Assumption 1 and small linearisation error, $\hat{\mu}_k$ is approximately Gaussian with variance J_k^{-1}, giving $\Pr(\mu \geq \underline{\mu}_k) \approx 1-\delta$. This is an approximation, not a finite-sample guarantee; it fails if c is wrong, noise is non-Gaussian, or μ changes within the estimator memory. Section 7 measures empirical coverage.*

4.4 Spatial staleness

Let s_{exc} be the last position at which a measurement was informative, $\phi_k^2/R > I_{\text{th}}$. The planner uses

$$\mu_{\text{plan}}(s) = \mu_{\min} + (\underline{\mu}_k - \mu_{\min})\, e^{-(s-s_{\text{exc}})/\ell}, \tag{11}$$

so trust in the bound decays with distance from where the surface was last observed, with length scale ℓ. Anchoring at s_{exc} rather than the current position matters: a decay anchored at the vehicle moves with it and never reaches the curve.

5 Speed Planning on the Friction Bound

On a grid s_i with spacing Δs over a horizon H, the planner computes the curvature limit $v_i^\kappa = \min\{v_{\max}, \sqrt{\eta\mu_{\text{plan},i} g/|\kappa_i|}\}$, a forward pass $v_{i+1} \leq \sqrt{v_i^2 + 2a_{x,i}^{\max}\Delta s}$ with $a_{x,i}^{\max} = \min\{a_{\text{acc}}, \sqrt{(\eta\mu_{\text{plan},i} g)^2 - (v_i^2\kappa_i)^2}\}$, and a backward pass with the full braking capacity, taking the pointwise minimum as in [9]. The terminal speed is limited so that the vehicle can stop within 30 m under $\mu_{\min}$, keeping each plan recoverable if the bound drops. The plan is recomputed at 5 Hz.

Algorithm 1 Excitation-aware friction-bounded speed planning

```
Initialise μ̂_0 = μ_0, J = J_0, s_exc = 0
for each time step k (100 Hz) do
    Reconstruct y_k by (3) and α_k from the state estimate
    Update μ̂_k, J_k by (6)–(9); compute μ_k by (10)
    if φ_k^2/R > I_th then s_exc ← s_k
    Every 0.2 s: build μ_plan(s) by (11) and replan v(s)
    Track v(s) and the path with the low-level controller
end for
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Table 1: Simulation parameters

Vehicle	$m = 1500$ kg, $I_z = 2500$ kg m^2, $l_f = 1.2$, $l_r = 1.6$ m
	$C_f = 80$, $C_r = 100$ kN/rad, $\delta_{\max} = 30°, 60°$/s, $\tau_\delta = 0.08$ s
Estimator	$\lambda = 0.995$ (100 Hz), $\mu_0 = 0.6$, $\mu_{\min} = 0.3$, $z_\delta = 1.645$
Planner	$\eta = 0.85$, $H = 250$ m, $\Delta s = 2$ m, $v_{\max} = 25$ m/s
	$a_{\text{acc}} = 3$ m/s^2, $\ell = 150$ m, $I_{\text{th}} = 1$

Proposition 1 (Conditional feasibility)**.** *If the true friction satisfies $\mu(s) \geq \mu_{\text{plan}}(s)$ over the planning horizon, the planned profile satisfies* (1) *at every grid point.*

Proof. By construction each planned point satisfies $\sqrt{a_{x,i}^2 + a_{y,i}^2} \leq \eta\mu_{\text{plan},i} g \leq \eta\mu(s_i) g$. □

The result is deterministic; the probabilistic content lies in whether $\mu \geq \mu_{\text{plan}}$. Grid discretisation and tracking error are not covered and are absorbed by η.

6 Simulation Study

6.1 Plant, controller and sensing

The plant is a planar dynamic bicycle model (states X, Y, ψ, v_x, v_y, r) with the tire model (2) on both axles, a friction ellipse reducing lateral capacity to $\sqrt{\mu^2 - (a_x/g)^2}$, longitudinal acceleration saturated at $0.95\mu g$, steering lag τ_δ and steering-rate limit, integrated by forward Euler at 100 Hz. Steering uses curvature feedforward with preview plus heading and Stanley-type lateral feedback; speed uses feedforward plus proportional feedback. The estimator receives (3) computed from the plant's a_y and $\dot{r}$, with Gaussian noise $\sigma_y = 0.02$ on y and $\sigma_\alpha = 0.1°$ on α. In each run the true stiffness of both axles is scaled by a factor drawn uniformly from $[0.9, 1.1]$ while the estimator keeps the nominal c, so model mismatch is present throughout. Parameters are in Table 1.

6.2 Track and scenarios

All scenarios share one 1134 m track: an 80 m straight, a 90° left and a 90° right curve (radius 60 m) separated by 80 m, a 420 m straight, a 120° left test curve (radius 60 m) and a 120 m straight, with 20 m clothoid transitions; the vehicle starts at 10 m/s. **S1 (hidden drop):** $\mu = 0.9$, dropping to 0.4 60 m into the long straight. **S2:** $\mu = 0.35$ throughout. **S3:** $\mu = 0.9$ throughout.

Table 2: Monte Carlo results (20 runs, mean ± 95% CI). Sat.: tire-saturation time; Dep.: runs with lane departure; Time: traversal time (not meaningful for runs that departed); Cov.: bound coverage.

Method	Sat. [s]	Dep. [%]	Time [s]	Cov.
S1 hidden drop				
B1 Fixed-nominal	17.8±0.0	100	56.3±0.0	–
B2 Fixed-conservative	0.0±0.0	0	69.2±0.0	–
B3 Certainty-equivalent	31.5±3.2	100	73.5±3.3	–
A1 No forgetting	17.7±0.1	100	59.7±0.3	0.36
A2 No spatial decay	8.0±1.7	60	57.5±0.2	0.61
Proposed	0.2±0.1	0	58.6±0.4	0.54
S2 low friction				
B1 Fixed-nominal	64.3±0.0	100	69.7±0.0	–
B2 Fixed-conservative	0.0±0.0	0	69.2±0.0	–
B3 Certainty-equivalent	89.8±5.4	100	98.0±5.6	–
A1 No forgetting	1.3±0.7	0	66.7±0.4	0.59
A2 No spatial decay	0.7±0.5	0	66.9±0.4	0.84
Proposed	0.6±0.4	0	67.1±0.4	0.84
S3 high friction				
B1 Fixed-nominal	0.0±0.0	0	51.0±0.0	–
B2 Fixed-conservative	0.0±0.0	0	69.2±0.0	–
B3 Certainty-equivalent	0.3±0.2	0	51.8±0.4	–
A1 No forgetting	0.0±0.0	0	54.9±0.5	0.57
A2 No spatial decay	0.8±0.3	0	52.9±0.4	0.75
Proposed	0.0±0.0	0	56.2±0.8	0.76

6.3 Methods and metrics

B1 fixed $\mu = 0.9$; **B2** fixed $\mu = \mu_{\min}$; **B3** certainty-equivalent, planning with $\hat{\mu}$; **A1** the bound without forgetting ($\lambda = 1$); **A2** the bound without spatial staleness ($\ell \to \infty$); **P** proposed. All share the track, controller, η, noise seeds and stiffness draws. Metrics: *saturation time*, total time with either axle above 95% utilisation; *departure*, lateral error above 2 m; traversal time; *coverage*, fraction of time with true μ at the vehicle $\geq \underline{\mu}$. Each configuration is run with 20 seeds; we report means with 95% confidence intervals and a Wilcoxon signed-rank test on paired saturation times.

7 Results

Hidden drop (S1). Table 2 and Fig. 2 show the central failure of certainty equivalence: after converging to $\hat{\mu} \approx 0.9$ in the first curves, B3 sees no excitation on the straight, keeps planning for high friction, and enters the test curve at 25 m/s on $\mu = 0.4$; every run saturates the tires (31.5 s) and departs. Fixed-nominal planning (B1) and the bound without forgetting (A1) fail the same way. Without spatial staleness (A2) the bound decays too slowly (Remark 1) and 60% of runs depart. The proposed method brakes before the curve, saturates for 0.2 ± 0.1 s and never departs; the difference from B3 is significant ($p = 1.9 \times 10^{-6}$). It is 10.6 s faster than the conservative B2.

Persistent low friction (S2). B3 starts from the prior mean $\mu_0 = 0.6$ and overestimates friction until the tires saturate, leading to departures in every run. The bound-based methods stay near the limit with less than 1.5 s of saturation and are 2–2.5 s faster than B2.

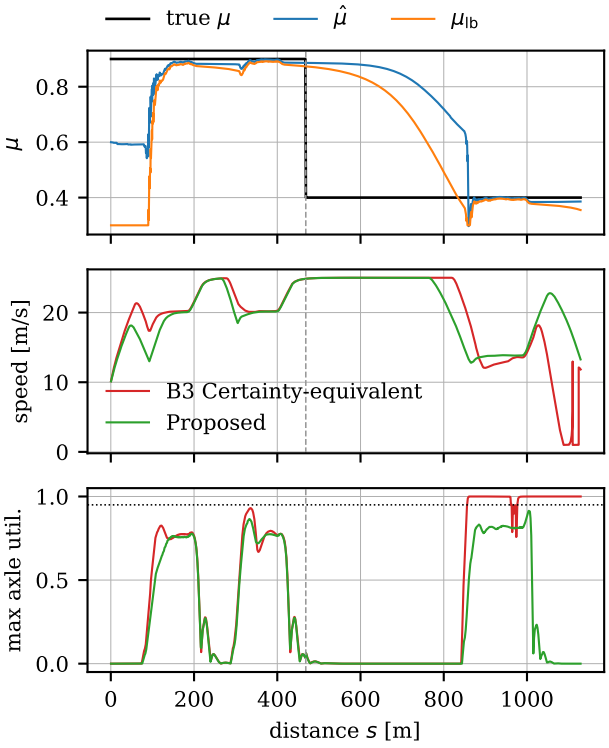


Figure 2: Scenario S1, one run. Top: true friction, estimate and bound (proposed). Middle and bottom: speed and maximum axle utilisation for certainty-equivalent planning (B3) and the proposed method. The dashed line marks the friction drop.

Cost of conservatism (S3). On high friction the proposed method needs 56.2 ± 0.8 s versus 51.0 s for B1 and 69.2 s for B2, recovering 71% of the gap. The remaining loss arises because the bound relaxes on straights and must be re-earned at each curve entry.

Trade-off and staleness length. Fig. 3 places the proposed method alone in the region of both low saturation and short traversal time. Sweeping ℓ (10 seeds) gives S3 times of 56.7, 55.2, 54.6 and 53.9 s for $\ell = 50, 100, 150, 300$ m with zero S1 saturation in all four, while $\ell \to \infty$ gives 52.7 s but 7.6 s of S1 saturation; ℓ is a tunable trust distance with a wide safe range in this setup.

Coverage and stiffness mismatch. Coverage is below the nominal 95% in every scenario (Table 2). In S1 this is expected by construction: right after the drop the vehicle is on $\mu = 0.4$ while the bound still reflects the dry surface, and safety comes from spatial staleness rather than from the bound itself. In S2 and S3 the shortfall is caused by stiffness mismatch. Sweeping the true-to-model stiffness ratio (10 seeds each) shows the mechanism: at 0.8, 0.9 and 1.0 coverage in S2 is ≥ 0.999 with no saturation, but at 1.1 coverage

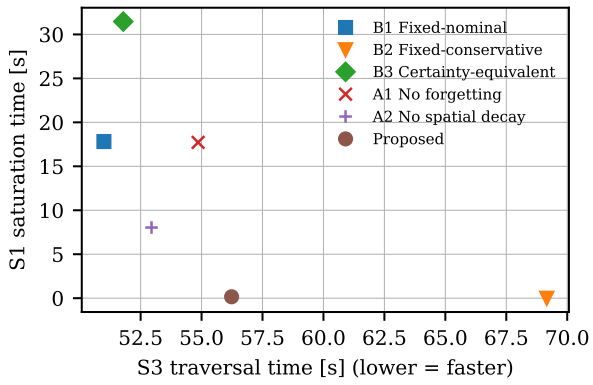


Figure 3: Safety–efficiency trade-off: S1 saturation time versus S3 traversal time (means over 20 runs).

falls to 0.59 with 2.9 s of saturation, and at 1.2 the method overestimates friction and saturates for 69 s. A stiffer-than-modelled tire produces more force at a given slip, which the estimator attributes to higher friction. Underestimating stiffness is therefore safe, and overestimating it is the main failure mode.

CARLA. [TODO: Run carla_friction_bound.py for S1 and S3 (all six methods, at least 10 seeds each), identify c in CARLA first with a low-speed steady-state test, and report the same metrics; until then all results above are simulation-only.]

8 Discussion and Limitations

The results are from a simplified simulation: a point-mass friction circle, static axle loads, ideal sensing of a_y and $\dot{r}$ with additive noise, and a tire model whose shape the estimator knows. The most important limitation is the dependence on c: the bound is only as trustworthy as the stiffness model, and a conservative (lower) stiffness value, or joint estimation of c in the linear region, should be used in practice. Slip-angle reconstruction requires a lateral-velocity estimate whose error enters the regressor. The spatial staleness model (11) is a design choice, not derived from road statistics; map or camera-based surface priors could replace it. Finally, the planner is passive: it never deliberately excites the tires. Planning for information—trading a small excitation manoeuvre for a tighter bound—is a dual-control problem and a direction for future work.

9 Conclusion

For a saturating tire model, information about friction grows with the sixth power of tire utilisation, so ordinary driving leaves friction largely unidentified. An excitation-aware lower confidence bound with stabilised forgetting and spatial staleness, used in a friction-circle speed planner, removed tire saturation and lane departures after a hidden friction drop in simulation, where certainty-equivalent planning failed in every run, while recovering 71% of the speed lost by fixed conservative planning. The method is sensitive to overestimated tire stiffness, which must be addressed before deployment.

Acknowledgment

[TODO: Funding and support. Required by IEEE policy: state that AI tools (name the tool) were used to draft text, generate simulation code and figures, and that the author verified all content.]

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